

Exegesis of I Corinthians 4:1-13

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REL 362: Interpreting Sacred Traditions

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“¹ Think of us in this way, as servants of Christ and stewards of God’s mysteries. ² Moreover, it is required of stewards that they be found trustworthy. ³ But with me it is a very small thing that I should be judged by you or by any human court. I do not even judge myself. ⁴ I am not aware of anything against myself, but I am not thereby acquitted. It is the Lord who judges me. ⁵ Therefore do not pronounce judgment before the time, before the Lord comes, who will bring to light the things now hidden in darkness and will disclose the purposes of the heart. Then each one will receive commendation from God.

⁶ I have applied all this to Apollos and myself for your benefit, brothers and sisters, so that you may learn through us the meaning of the saying, ‘Nothing beyond what is written,’ so that none of you will be puffed up in favor of one against another. ⁷ For who sees anything different in you? What do you have that you did not receive? And if you received it, why do you boast as if it were not a gift?

⁸ Already you have all you want! Already you have become rich! Quite apart from us you have become kings! Indeed, I wish that you had become kings, so that we might be kings with you! ⁹ For I think that God has exhibited us apostles as last of all, as though sentenced to death, because we have become a spectacle to the world, to angels and to mortals. ¹⁰ We are fools for the sake of Christ, but you are wise in Christ. We are weak, but you are strong. You are held in honor, but we in disrepute. ¹¹ To the present hour we are hungry and thirsty, we are poorly clothed and beaten and homeless, ¹² and we grow weary from the work of our own hands. When reviled, we bless; when persecuted, we endure; ¹³ when slandered, we speak kindly. We have become like the rubbish of the world, the dregs of all things, to this very day,” (I Cor. 4:1-13).

Prior to this point in his letter, Paul addressed the Corinthians’ spiritual problems in a civil and generally calm manner. In this section however, Paul chides the church directly. Dripping with sarcasm, he condemns the Corinthians using rhetoric that would have been familiar to them. In his emotional exhortation, Paul asserts his apostolic authority as being from God and depicts this apostleship as a model for Christian life. Paul expresses the servant-like nature of apostleship as he details his low stature and humility. He juxtaposes this imagery with a description of the Corinthians’ puffed up self-exaltation, reminding them that their human self-judgment means nothing since it can only examine a person’s external traits (such as wealth and perceived wisdom). Paul instead stresses the gravity of God’s judgment when He comes, since God will discern each person’s heart and will reward each person accordingly.

The Roman city of Corinth was located on a narrow strip of land between the Adriatic and Aegean seas. Because of this, the city drew in many merchants, settlers, and freed slaves. Corinth prided itself in its openness to its many immigrants from diverse social, economic, and ethnic backgrounds. Paul established the Christian community in Corinth around 50 AD and stayed with them for a couple years (Powell 278). While undoubtedly many of the Christians here were poor, there was a significant minority that was wealthy and used its wealth for the benefit of the church (NISB 2036). However, after he left, the Corinthian church became divided and needed correction. The community’s troubles stemmed from Corinthian culture, which was known for its hedonistic lavishness and sexuality. The church’s diversity may have also been a point of contention between rival factions within the community, as factions may have attempted to separate themselves from each other on social, economic, or ethnic grounds (Powell 278).

I Corinthians is the second corrective letter written by Paul to the Corinthians (5:9). In it, Paul admonishes the Christians there for their internal divisions (1:11) and pridefulness of their own wisdom (1:20) and wealth (1:26). In the second half of chapter 3, Paul chides the Corinthians for their pridefulness in their own accomplishments and their belief that such works would reward them on judgment day (3:13). Paul continues by expressing the differences between how the world views wisdom compared to how God judges wisdom (3:18). This sentiment is echoed later on.

At the very end of chapter 3 and leading into chapter 4, Paul focuses on the ministers and authorities in the Church. The Corinthians were boasting of their allegiance to particular apostolic authorities, claiming to be exclusive disciples of Cephas, Apollos, or Paul (1:12), which led to internal quarreling in the church (3:3). Paul condemns this behavior on many grounds. Paul reminds them of their unity within the “body of Christ,” wherein each individual member of the Church possesses unique spiritual gifts (12:12-27). When the members of the church quarrel, they divide Christ (1:13). When the members of the church internally recognize their individual vocations before God, they will each receive commendation from Him (4:5). The Corinthians believe that they should pledge their allegiance to individual ministers. However, Paul refutes this by telling them that it is not their place to serve the apostles, but rather, it is the duty of the apostles to serve them (3:21-22). The ministers are servants to the Corinthians just as the Corinthians themselves belong to God (3:23). However, although they were servants of the Corinthians, the apostles were not subject to them. The apostles were subjects only to Christ for the benefit of the Corinthians, and thus did not concern themselves with their individual popularity in Corinth. This captures Paul’s understanding of the Church’s hierarchy, wherein all ministers are laborers for the sake of the Church (3:8) and all creation is subject to Christ (15:27).

In addition to their servanthood to Christ, Paul also recognizes the apostles’ calling as “stewards of God’s mysteries,” (4:1). In the Greco-Roman world, a steward was the chief servant of a household or city. In fact, there was even a city steward within the Corinthian community who was identified by the name Erastus in Paul’s letter to the Romans (Rom. 16:23). Paul’s metaphor here highlights the responsibility that the apostles held through administering the mysteries of God to the Church (Collins 168).¹ Paul speaks earlier about this mystery of God, saying, “I did not come proclaiming the mystery of God to you in lofty words or wisdom,” (2:1). This mystery, Paul describes, is the hidden wisdom of God (2:7) which is made available only through the instruction of the Holy Spirit (2:10). With this wisdom, the people of God are able to discern the gifts that are bestowed on them by God (2:12). Thus, the mystery of God is a gift and does not warrant boasting. Paul’s unusual choice of the word “mystery,” which is rarely used in his other letters, suggests an appeal to the Corinthians by using familiar Greek vocabulary. It is possible, for example, that Paul was attempting to borrow the language of the Stoics and, in a way, Christianize their terminology (Fee 104). Another possibility is that it could have been the language used by dissidents within the Corinthian community and was

¹ Jesus too recognizes this responsibility when He says, “Who, then, is the faithful and prudent manager (which uses the same Greek word οἰκονόμος as I Cor. 4:1) whom his master will put in charge of his slaves, to give them their allowance of food at the proper time?” (Lk. 12:42). In unity with Paul’s statement, one could connect the “allowance of food” with the “mysteries of God,” wherein the Sacrament of the Eucharist is a mystery of God, though this was probably not the intention of the authors.

echoed back by Paul as a part of his exhortation (Collins 125). Either way, Paul's decided use of the word was directed at helping the Greek Corinthians to better understand his message.

Trustworthiness, Paul notes, is a requirement for the apostles (4:2). Trustworthiness was an inherent quality for a steward since stewards were entrusted to care for the household in the owner's absence (Collins 172). Indeed, the apostles were entrusted with the task of caring for the Church until Jesus's return on judgment day. However, Paul is not concerned about being perceived as trustworthy to his congregations. Rather, Paul stresses the importance of trustworthiness in the eyes of God instead of by any eyes of man (4:3). His trustworthiness can be judged only by He whom Paul is committing himself as steward (Fee 161). Interestingly, Paul notes that since God alone can judge his stewardship, Paul cannot even judge himself (4:4). This statement is made in reference to his trustworthiness and, by extension, his effectiveness as an apostle. Therefore, this statement does not apply to evaluations in other parts of his life, and neither is he saying that the Corinthians cannot partake in self-judgment. For example, when writing about the Lord's Supper, Paul advises partakers to examine themselves before eating and drinking unworthily (11:29). This self-judgment, however, is separated from the judgment of God (11:31). This deflection of self-judgment in relation to his ministry makes his next statement even more pronounced (Fee 163).

Paul brings his paragraph to a close with an emphatic "therefore," bringing attention to the final imperative of his sentence. As a steward of the Church, he issues a command to the Corinthians saying, "do not pronounce judgment before the time, before the Lord comes," (4:5). As with Paul's aversion to self-judgment, this command against judgment is not universally applied, but rather applies only to their judgment of Paul's apostleship. For example, judgment is still required when discerning disputes among believers in their community (6:5). Only the Lord² can judge the steward. This judgment will happen on "the Day," often known as judgment day (3:13). Paul's inclusion of this eschatological imagery functions as a reminder to the Corinthians of the impending return of their master (Collins 171). Indeed, Paul's use of eschatological language throughout his letter reflects the Corinthians' need for a renewed eschatological perspective that should characterize their entire lives.

By this point, Paul's point has been made. But yet, he continues by giving a description of the judge, detailing that the Lord has the ability to examine a person's heart. This context reassures the Corinthians that the Lord is a capable and just judge (Fee 163). He also uses this as an opportunity to remind the community of their individual worth, stating that from the judge, "each one" will receive commendation as a result. In saying this, Paul is not giving the Corinthians reason to boast, but rather emphasizes the fact that their individual commendations come "from God," (Conzelmann 84). Paul stresses the fact that the Corinthians possess nothing worthy of boasting that is not a gift from God. This becomes the central theme of the rest of the passage.

Paul cites the Corinthians' pridefulness as a reason for their disunity. In a phrase unique to his epistle, Paul describes each Corinthian as being "puffed up," (4:6) or arrogant (Fee 169). However, he discredits their pridefulness at its root, critiquing the basis for their boasting. In a series of three rhetorical questions, Paul teaches them that everything important that they have in their lives is the result of God's grace and not of their own accomplishment (4:7). The first question ("For who sees anything different in you?") emphasizes that there are no grounds for any of them to exalt themselves over another, since all differences that they might have are ultimately determined by their creator (Fee 170). The second ("What do you have that you did

2 Paul uses the Greek word κύριος, which may be rendered into either "Lord" or "master," (Fee 163).

not receive?") marks the Corinthians as ungrateful, homing in on their presumptuous selfishness. Finally, the third ("And if you received it, why do you boast as if it were a gift?") hammers in his point in case the Corinthians hadn't yet understood: they possess nothing worthy of boasting that is not a gift of God! In these three questions, Paul leads them to a fuller understanding of grace so that their eyes can be opened to the ridiculousness of their boasting, which is at the heart of their quarrels (Fee 171).

After the rhetorical questions, Paul engages in another unique form of rhetoric. Paul uses sarcasm to once again humble the boastful Corinthians and bring to light the root of some of the social differences that divided them. Repeating twice that the Corinthians have "already" attained their worldly desires, Paul sets up for his next exhortation by illuminating the differences between the worldly-minded Corinthians and the steward-like apostles (4:8).

"The three verbs used by Paul in the ironic triad of 4:8—to be satiated, to be rich, and to act like kings—were used in Hellenistic literature to characterize the rich and powerful. It may be that some of the better-off Corinthians were acting like kings, treating others with disdain, and acting as if there were no limits to their freedom. Such an attitude would have led to a divided community," (Collins 178).

Indeed, Paul says, he wishes that the Corinthians truly were kings so that he could be one with them. Paul is not saying that he wishes to live in prideful abundance like them, since that would contradict his argument. Instead, this is yet another reference to their eschatological future (Hays 70). It is a reminder that the Corinthians do not need to boast about their temporary treasures since they will be like kings on the last day. After their judgment, when they receive their commendations from God, they will receive the fruits of Christ's resurrection (15:23) and will reign with Him as saints (6:3). But yet, disappointed, Paul knows that this is not what the Corinthians currently are (Fee 174).

Again, the Corinthians exalted themselves for their outward signs of wealth and perceived wisdom. Paul uses this to contrast the Corinthians with the apostles and their opposing views of Christian life. Paul elevates the apostles as an example, not for their treasures or honor, but for their suffering. In the same way that the Romans would carry prisoners at the end of the parade to be mocked as they headed toward prison or execution, the apostles are mocked (4:9). They are reviled, scorned, and sentenced to death,³ not unlike the mockery that Jesus endured at the hands of the Romans. Paul claims to be scorned not only by humans, but also by angels. This highlights the universal sense of the passage and does not make much sense taken literally (Fee 175). Paul may also be drawing upon Jesus's own imagery that the "last shall be first," which explains that by their humility the apostles will be exalted by God (Mt. 20:16).⁴ By borrowing Jesus's rhetoric, Paul is strengthening his own, since Jesus is of course an undisputed authority for the Christian community.

Here, Paul reaches the crux of his exhortation wherein he contrasts a list of the apostles' tribulations to the Corinthians' prosperity in order to make the irony of the Corinthians' boastfulness evident.

³ Interestingly, this was the ultimate reality that most of the apostles would later face.

⁴ Jesus used this phrase in His parable of the laborers in the vineyard to condemn the prideful laborers who, ungracious to the gifts given to them by their master, boasted that they were more worthy of payment (Mt. 20:1-16). This situation shares remarkable similarities to what we see with the boastful Corinthians.

“The twelve items on Paul’s list are organized in a chiastic pattern (A-B-A’), in which the first unit (A, v. 10) and third (A’, vv. 12b-13a) consist of three elements, each of which provides a contrast between Paul and Apollos and the Corinthian troublemakers... . The central unit (B, vv. 11-12a)... portrays the kind of life Paul and his companion evangelists had to live. It depicts Paul and Apollos as being in a situation in which they can identify with the Corinthian have-nots,” (Collins 184).

The first comparison of the list hearkens back to Paul’s earlier expositions on wisdom and foolishness (4:10). Paul now affirms that the Corinthians are wise in Christ and the apostles foolish. Paul is likely forming this discrepancy in terms of worldly wisdom and foolishness (as opposed to the godly wisdom and foolishness that he talks about earlier), which brings out the irony in his exhortation. Likewise, he pits the apostles against the Corinthians as a comparison of weak against strong, and later as of disrepute against honor. Again, Paul in no way lauds the Corinthians’ perceived wisdom, strength, or honor, but uses them as an ironic contrast to the model of the suffering apostles.

Paul follows these three comparisons with a sixfold list of tribulations that the apostles endure (4:11). These tribulations depict the apostles as destitute, lacking in sufficient material resources that are needed to survive. Such a list reflects a certain Hellenistic literary style that was employed by Greek philosophers and Jewish writers alike. These lists were often fabricated or exaggerated from reality. Their primary purpose was to emphasize the virtue and perseverance of the woeful individuals and communities in the face of external hardship (Collins 184). Thus, the hardships Paul describes might have been embellished to fit the literary convention such that he could draw attention to the apostles’ fortitude and moral high ground in relation to the Corinthians. However, the sixth hardship – “we grow weary from the work of our own hands,” (4:12) – is out of place amidst the desolation Paul describes earlier. While weariness is certainly a hardship, it is not quite as devastating as hunger, thirst, and homelessness. It may suggest that he was from a wealthier class than most, or otherwise that he is accentuating his woes to the wealthier members of the Corinthian church (Collins 185). If nothing else, it effectively demonstrates that he is not yet the king he longs to be (4:8) (Fee 179).

In the final triad, Paul pairs the apostles’ afflictions with their responses to them (4:12-13). Through this, his focus slowly shifts back from his tribulation to his ministry to the Corinthians (Collins 185). The revilement, persecution, and slander that he and the apostles face are insignificant because they understand that their vocation requires them to “bless those who curse [them],” (Lk. 6:28). Likewise, the endurance that they demonstrate “to this day” (4:10, 13) is in sharp opposition to the Corinthians who believe that they have “already” become rich like kings (4:8). Finally, the kind words that the apostles speak to those who slander them is itself evocative to the encouragement that Paul is currently giving to the Corinthians as a response to their division, divisiveness, and their unfaithfulness to their apostolic leaders (Hays 72).

In the same way that he prefaced the list by describing the apostles as “spectacle[s] to the world,” (4:9), Paul concludes the list by describing the apostles as “dregs” and “rubbish of the world,” (4:13). These statements bookend the passage to impress upon the Corinthians an understanding of the scorn that the apostolic stewards endure as a result of their applied trustworthiness. Ultimately, Paul wishes to be an example to the Corinthians (4:16), and this exhortation shows the gravity of the sort of discipleship that he expects from them.

Indeed, Paul has applied these traits to himself and Apollos in expectation that the prideful Corinthians should understand the meaning of the saying, “Nothing beyond what is

written,” (4:6). Although the meaning of this difficult phrase has been lost to history, Paul used it under the assumption that the Corinthians would understand it (Collins 178). Paul also understands the phrase as having some sort of meaningful connection to the well-being of the Corinthian community. Paul assumes that if they reinterpreted the phrase under his provided application, they would refrain from the pridefulness that was at the heart of their quarrels. Given the expected result of this phrase, it is possible that “[that which] is written” is not in reference to a particular source of doctrinal truth. Rather, it could be a reflection of Paul’s heretofore call for the Corinthians to live in a loving community.

Paul’s use of external rhetoric throughout this passage (and throughout the epistle as a whole) is frequent and intentional. Paul uses verbiage and expressions that he knew were familiar and meaningful to the Corinthian community. In light of this, it becomes apparent that Paul’s list of tribulations (4:10-13) may be borrowing from another New Testament tradition: Jesus’s beatitudes. Figure I provided on page 7 displays a side-by-side comparison of Jesus’s beatitudes as recorded in Matthew’s gospel alongside Paul’s list of tribulations. While the comparisons are not each a 1:1 match (although #s 4, 7, 8, and 9 share some remarkable similarities between the two sources), both lists are almost identical in terms of their structure, content, and purpose.

Although the Matthean tradition developed 15-20 years after I Corinthians, it is possible that Paul and Matthew were both familiar with the beatitudes or drew upon the same kerygmatic tradition to shape their teachings and writings. Therefore, assuming that some variation of the beatitudes were included in the catechesis given to the Corinthians (11:2), it makes sense for Paul to draw upon them as a familiar source of authority to correct the Corinthian church. By drawing upon the beatitudes, Paul was able to better articulate to the Corinthians the message of humility and eschatological endurance embedded in his list of tribulations. If Paul truly did draw upon the beatitudes with the understanding that his Corinthian audience was familiar with them, it opens up the possibility that Paul was referencing similar teachings elsewhere. Most notably, these teachings could be a part of the mysterious teachings that “[are] written” to the Corinthians (4:6). Because of their connection to Jesus, these teachings would have had a significant authoritative connection to the Corinthians. This connection would help them better grasp Paul’s call for them to live selflessly in community with one another.

Figure I.

A side-by-side comparison of the Matthean beatitudes and Paul's list of tribulations:

	Jesus (Matthew 5:3-12)	Paul (I Corinthians 4:10-13)
1	Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.	We are fools for the sake of Christ, but you are wise in Christ.
2	Blessed are those who mourn, for they will be comforted.	We are weak, but you are strong.
3	Blessed are the meek, for they will inherit the earth.	You are held in honor, but we in disrepute.
4	Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness, for they will be filled.	To the present hour we are hungry and thirsty,
5	Blessed are the merciful, for they will receive mercy.	We are poorly clothed and beaten and homeless,
6	Blessed are the pure in heart, for they will see God.	And we grow weary from the work of our own hands.
7	Blessed are the peacemakers, for they will be called children of God.	When reviled, we bless;
8	Blessed are those who are persecuted for righteousness' sake, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.	When persecuted, we endure;
9	Blessed are you when people revile you and persecute you and utter all kinds of evil against you falsely on my account.	We have become like the rubbish of the world, the dregs of all things, to this very day.
10	Rejoice and be glad, for your reward is great in heaven, for in the same way they persecuted the prophets who were before you.	Then each one will receive commendation from God. (4:5)

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